

Key squares matter more than chasing

Endgame Technique

THE IDEA

In a king-and-pawn ending, key squares are squares where the stronger king can often secure promotion with correct play. Their identity depends on the pawn's file and rank. Rook pawns have important exceptions because the board edge limits access.

WORKED EXAMPLE

With a white pawn on e5, squares on the sixth rank in front of it can be critical for the white king. Reaching such squares can be more useful than directly chasing the defending king sideways.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

Why should you avoid pushing a pawn before checking king access?

ANSWER AND REASONING

The push may change the opposition, remove a waiting move, or let the defender blockade it. Improve the king first when that secures the pawn's advance.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Win access for the king before spending the pawn's tempo.